a judicial inquiry but didn't seem to make much progress. 'No judge was willing to take up a politically sensitive case,' a senior minister told me.

Worried about the fallout, the Shah–Modi duo acted swiftly. The Gujarat government appointed its own inquiry commission to look into the case. The young woman's father approached the Supreme Court and asked the court to restrain the Centre from ordering a parallel inquiry. The father even issued a statement, interestingly released from the BJP office, saying that it was he who had asked for security for his daughter. Whether that 'security' included an hourly update of her movements, including who she was having lunch with, is anybody's guess. The woman in question and her husband were reportedly flown out of Ahmedabad to Paris. When our reporter visited the family's flat in Ahmedabad, he found no one there. Later, a BJP source admitted to me, 'We were a little worried initially and had to go into damage control because this issue could have really blown up in our face.'

This wasn't the first I had heard of Snoopgate. In 2012, a senior police officer from Gujarat, Kuldeep Sharma, had met me for breakfast, claiming he had information that would gravely damage Modi and Shah. 'They have been illegally snooping on a woman,' he said. I asked for proof; he promised to get back.

Sharma was a decorated police officer who had now fallen foul of the Shah–Modi duo. He had approved the Sohrabuddin fake encounter report and had been also investigating a cooperative bank fraud in which Shah was allegedly involved. The Modi government hit back, he says, by putting his brother Pradeep Sharma, an IAS officer, in jail. Pradeep had been seen in the company of the woman who was now the subject of the Snoopgate controversy. Modi had reportedly met the woman who was a landscape architect, along with the IAS officer, while inaugurating a hill garden project in Bhuj in 2005 when Pradeep Sharma was district collector there. In his affidavit before the Supreme Court, Sharma claimed that Modi was besotted with the woman and had asked the home department to keep a tab on her. Gujarat government sources claimed that it was Pradeep Sharma who was actually in love with the woman. 'This is a complicated story, but *daal mein zaroor kuch kaala hai*,' was the response of a senior Gujarat